

An Autistic Adult in Your Training / Course

For trainers, vocational coaches, mentors & CPD instructors — teaching an autistic adult learner.

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means an adult learner's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." In the right format, that focus is a real asset — depth, retention and attention to detail. But most training assumes polytropic habits: rapid task-switching, group exercises, "ice-breakers," verbal-only instructions and last-minute changes — all of which tax a monotropic learner. Small adjustments (clarity, predictability, written materials, fewer forced switches) make your training accessible to everyone and let an autistic learner's strengths show.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Engrossed in one module; "checks out" elsewhere	Deep, single-track focus — channel it, don't fight it
Won't join pair-work or "ice-breakers"	High social load, not disengagement; learns better solo or in writing
Asks for detail, rules, or "why" repeatedly	Literal, single-channel processing — a sign of engagement
Falls behind after an overload of group days	Probable overwhelm/burnout, not lack of effort
Communicates better by email/chat than aloud	Single-channel communication; writing reduces the load

Try this

- **Put materials and instructions in writing**, in advance — slides, handouts, schedules and criteria; avoid "listen and remember" only.
- **Predictability over surprise** — a clear agenda, advance notice of changes, a quiet break-out space.
- **Offer real alternatives** to forced group work and participation — solo tasks, written reflection, a defined role in a group.
- **One instruction at a time, with reasons**; allow processing time and written follow-up.
- **Play to the interest and strength** where you can; depth is where autistic learners often shine.

Avoid this

- Last-minute changes, surprise "share with the group" demands, or cold-calling.
- Equating eye contact or verbal fluency with engagement or competence.
- Piling on simultaneous channels (talk + read + discuss + decide) without structure.

When to get more support

Watch for signs of **overwhelm or burnout** (exhaustion, withdrawal, dropping skills) and check in privately and literally. Signpost workplace mentoring, **Access to Work / disability services**, and reasonable adjustments; an autistic adult is the expert on what helps — ask them.

If the learner is a woman

Women are over-represented among late-diagnosed adults and mask heavily, so exhaustion and difference may be hidden behind a competent exterior. Don't let a polished surface override signs of overload.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Parts 2 & 3.4), **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 3) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2019, *Monotropism at School*; 2023); Dwyer (2025); Knight (2021, *tunnels not tasks*); Wood (2019). Full citations are in the source drafts.